

or conflict. It is essential that your colleagues understand their goals and know how to achieve them, because a lack of clarity may lead to misunderstandings and disagreements in your workplace.

Create space for both formal and informal communication. Get to know and understand your team members. This makes it easier to pick up on any causes of tension.

CAUSES OF CONFLICT

To resolve conflict, you need to understand its root causes. Do not simply take things at face value—look for the underlying reasons. These causes commonly fall into the following groups:

- **Differing personalities and working styles** can clash, when people prefer to behave and work in a particular way.
- **Stress caused by pressure**, such as demanding deadlines or a lack of training, can cause tempers to fray.
- **Lack of clarity** can lead to misunderstandings between people with opposing views and opinions.
- **Sense of being undervalued** or “not heard” at work can make people become dissatisfied and argumentative.

“Peace is not the absence of conflict, but the ability to cope with it.”

Mahatma Gandhi, Indian politician and activist

Compromising

This entails finding a mutually acceptable solution, giving both sides something but not all of what they want. It suits many situations, whether you are handling conflict between yourself and a team member or mediating a dispute among colleagues.

Collaborating

This approach means searching for a position that fully satisfies both sides. It involves digging deeper into the sources of conflict. Use it when an issue is important and merits the time and effort invested.

Competing

This involves pursuing your concerns at the other person's expense. Competing relies on using power and your ability to argue. It is useful when there is a time pressure and reaching a solution is vital.

